

C2 English Vocabulary List (CEFR)

50 words at CEFR C2. Definitions and examples: Wordineer. IPA: CMU Pronouncing Dictionary. Frequency: wordfreq (Zipf, en). Source: wordineer.com/esl-vocabulary-cefr/c2/. License: CC BY 4.0.

Featured cards

debacle · noun · /dɪˈbɑːkəl/

A complete and shameful failure

“The launch turned into a public debacle.”

esoteric · adjective · /ɪˈsɒtɪrɪk/

Known or understood by only a few

“His research covers esoteric parts of physics.”

egregious · adjective · /ɪˈɡrɪdiəs/

Very bad and easily noticed

“The report contained egregious errors.”

ephemeral · adjective · /ɪˈfɛmərəl/

Lasting for a very short time

“Fame can be ephemeral — enjoyed briefly and quickly forgotten.”

echelon · noun · /ɪˈkɛlən/

A level or rank within an organization

“He reached the top echelon of the firm.”

nadir · noun · /ˈneɪdər/

The lowest point of something

“That loss was the nadir of his career.”

zephyr · noun · /ˈzɛfər/

A soft, gentle breeze

“A cool zephyr moved through the trees.”

cognizant · adjective · /ˈkɒɡnɪzənt/

Aware of or knowing about something

“She is cognizant of the risks involved.”

panacea · noun · /ˈpænəsi/

A solution said to fix all problems

“Technology is not a panacea for schools.”

erudite · adjective · /ɪˈrʊdaɪt/

Showing great knowledge from long study

“The erudite professor spoke five languages.”

sanguine · adjective · /ˈsæŋwɪn/

Hopeful and positive about the future

“She remains sanguine about the election.”

maelstrom · noun · /ˈmeɪlstrɒm/

A situation of great confusion or trouble

“The country fell into a maelstrom of protest.”

apocryphal · adjective · /əˈpɒkrɪfəl/

Widely told but probably not true

“That story about the president is apocryphal.”

fastidious · adjective · /fæˈstɪdiəs/

Very concerned about small details

“He is fastidious about his shoes staying clean.”

bombastic · adjective · /bɒmˈbæstɪk/

Using long words to sound important

“His bombastic speech bored the crowd.”

cacophony · noun · /kəˈkɒfəni/

A loud and unpleasant mix of sounds

“A cacophony of horns filled the street.”

inscrutable · adjective · /ɪnˈskrʊtəbəl/

Impossible to understand or read

“His inscrutable face gave nothing away.”

recalcitrant · adjective · /rɪˈkælsɪtrənt/

Refusing to obey or cooperate

“The recalcitrant student ignored the teacher.”

effervescent · adjective · /ɪˈfɛrəvəsənt/

Full of energy and excitement

“Her effervescent laugh fills every room.”

perfunctory · adjective · /pəˈrʌfʊktəri/

Done quickly with little care

“He gave a perfunctory nod and left.”

denouement · noun · /ˈdeɪnuəmənt/

The final part of a story where things are resolved

“The novel’s denouement surprised every reader.”

ineffable · adjective · /ɪˈnɛfəbəl/

Too great to describe in words

“She felt an ineffable joy at her wedding.”

hackneyed · adjective · /ˈhæknɪd/

Used so often it has lost meaning

“The film relies on hackneyed jokes.”

quixotic · adjective · /kwɪˈkɒsɪtɪk/

Full of hope but unlikely to succeed

“Her quixotic plan to end hunger inspired many.”

obfuscate · verb · /əˈbʃʊskeɪt/

To make something hard to understand

"The report obfuscates the real numbers."

surreptitious · adjective · /sʊrˈpʰtʃʊs/

Done in secret to avoid notice

"He took a surreptitious photo of the painting."

chicanery · noun · /ˈtʃeɪkənəri/

The use of tricks to deceive

"The lawyer accused him of financial chicanery."

propitious · adjective · /prɒˈpʃʊs/

Giving a good chance of success; favorable

"The clear skies were propitious for the outdoor ceremony."

sycophant · noun ·

A person who flatters others excessively to gain advantage

"Surrounded by sycophants, the leader never heard honest advice."

iconoclast · noun · /aɪˈkɒnɒklæst/

A person who attacks common beliefs

"The artist was an iconoclast of his time."

obsequious · adjective · /əbˈsɪkwɪs/

Trying too hard to please someone in power

"The obsequious waiter praised every dish."

salubrious · adjective ·

Good for your health

"The town has a salubrious mountain climate."

garrulous · adjective · /ˈɡærjʊləs/

Talking a lot, often about small things

"My garrulous uncle told the same story twice."

solipsism · noun ·

The philosophical idea that only one's own mind is certain to exist

"His solipsism made it difficult for him to empathize with others."

desultory · adjective · /dɪˈsʊltəri/

Done without plan or purpose

"He made a desultory attempt at cleaning."

soporific · adjective ·

Making you feel sleepy

"The long lecture had a soporific effect."

antediluvian · adjective ·

Extremely old or old-fashioned

"His antediluvian phone still has a cord."

mellifluous · adjective ·

Sweet and smooth to hear

"She has a mellifluous singing voice."

limpid · adjective ·

Clear and easy to see through

"The limpid lake reflected the sky."

truculent · adjective · /trʊˈkjʊlənt/

Quick to argue or become violent

"The truculent fan shouted at the referee."

diaphanous · adjective · /daɪˈæfənəs/

Light and almost see-through

"She wore a diaphanous silk scarf."

pusillanimous · adjective · /pjuːˈlænɪməs/

Showing a lack of courage

"His pusillanimous silence angered the crowd."

copacetic · adjective ·

In good order or completely fine

"After the talk, everything felt copacetic."

equivocate · verb · /ˈkwɪvəˈkeɪt/

To use ambiguous language to avoid commitment or to mislead

"The politician equivocated rather than giving a direct answer."

lachrymose · adjective ·

Likely to cry or make people cry

"The lachrymose ending made me weep."

perspicacious · adjective · /pɜːspɪˈkeɪʃəs/

Having a ready insight; showing great mental penetration or discernment

"A perspicacious observer noticed the flaw in the argument immediately."

grandiloquent · adjective · /ˈɡrændɪləˈkwɪlənt/

Using fancy language to sound impressive

"The mayor gave a grandiloquent farewell speech."

pellucid · adjective ·

Very clear and easy to follow

"The teacher gave a pellucid explanation."

vicissitude · noun · /vɪˈsɪsɪtʊd/

A change in circumstances, often unwelcome

"He faced the vicissitudes of army life."

defenestrate · verb ·

To throw someone out of a window

"The angry king had his rival defenestrated."

All C2 words

antediluvian adjective
apocryphal adjective /əˈpɒkrɪfəl/
bombastic adjective /bɒmˈbæstɪk/
cacophony noun /kəˈkɒfəni/
chicanery noun /ˈʃiːkənəri/
cognizant adjective /ˈkɒɡnɪzənt/
copacetic adjective
debacle noun /deɪˈbækl/
defenestrate verb
denouement noun /ˈdeɪnuːmɛnt/
desultory adjective /dɪˈsʌltəri/
diaphanous adjective /daɪˈæfənəs/
echelon noun /ˈɛʃələn/
effervescent adjective /ˈɛfərˈvɛsənt/
egregious adjective /ɪˈɡrɪdʒəs/
ephemeral adjective /ɪˈfɛmərəl/
equivocate verb /ˈkwɪˈvɛkeɪt/
erudite adjective /ˈɛrʊdaɪt/
esoteric adjective /ˈɛsəˈtɪrɪk/
fastidious adjective /fæˈstɪdiəs/
garrulous adjective /ˈɡærjʊləs/
grandiloquent adjective /ˈɡrændɪlɒkwənt/
hackneyed adjective /ˈhæknɪd/
iconoclast noun /ˈaɪkənɒklæst/
ineffable adjective /ɪˈnɛfəbəl/
inscrutable adjective /ɪnˈskrʊtəbəl/
lachrymose adjective
limpid adjective
maelstrom noun /ˈmeɪlstrɒm/
mellifluous adjective
nadir noun /ˈneɪdər/
obfuscate verb /əˈbfʊskeɪt/
obsequious adjective /əˈbɪsɪkwɪəs/
panacea noun /ˈpænəsi/
pellucid adjective
perfunctory adjective /pərˈfʊktəri/
perspicacious adjective /pəˈspɪkəsɪəs/
propitious adjective /prəˈpɪtɪəs/
pusillanimous adjective /pjuːˈlænɪməs/
quixotic adjective /kwɪˈkɒsɪtɪk/
recalcitrant adjective /rɪˈkælsɪtrənt/
salubrious adjective
sanguine adjective /ˈsæŋwɪn/

solipsism noun
soporific adjective
surreptitious adjective /səˈrɪptɪʃəs/
sycophant noun
truculent adjective /ˈtrʊkjʊlənt/
vicissitude noun /vɪˈsɪsɪtʊd/
zephyr noun /ˈzɛfər/